Lesson Plan: Pre-writing

In this lesson, students will explore what they're going to write about and also learn how pre-writing is one of the most important parts of the critical thinking/writing process.

STUDENTS WILL…

- Review the assignment/prompt
- Understand what "critical thinking" is
- Pre-write on the topic
- Narrow their topic by identifying "the diamonds"

TEACHER WILL…

- Introduce Essay Prompt
- Break down "critical thinking"
- Lead students in Pre-writing activity

MATERIALS NEEDED

Slide deck · Student laptops/chromebooks and access to yawp.school

Instructions

1. Open with the game **"What's happening in this picture."** This is designed to engage students in a shared experience of critical thinking that involves observation and analysis.

   SLIDES 3–5

2. **Introduce the essay prompt.** Break the prompt down a little, particularly the guidelines for the type of essay they're being asked to write (formal, thesis, intro, body paragraphs, conclusion). Optional: Engage students by asking them to share some of their initial ideas.

   SLIDES 6, 7

3. Let the students know that you're going to teach them what to do when they get an essay prompt. You might ask them how they feel when they first read a prompt: anxious? overwhelmed? confused? excited? It can definitely feel like a lot to write an essay, but you're going to show them a practical process for getting started.

   SLIDE 8

4. Use the **Critical Essay Form** slide/handout to point students to the importance of the Thesis Statement (you can't begin writing an essay without first developing your thesis statement). Tell them that developing that thesis statement takes some time, and it begins with critical thinking: figuring out what we think about a topic.

   SLIDES 9–10

5. **Pre-Writing.**

   SLIDES 1–12

   a. Explain how we often know what we feel about a topic, but we sometimes don't know why we feel that way.

      SLIDE 13

i. Brian: "I always use the **'3 friends walk into a movie'** example, where I ask the kids to imagine we all go see a movie together (I might ask them for a popular movie title to include them). When we come out of the movie, student A (I use an actual student in the class as student A) might say, 'I loved that movie!' and I say, 'Great! Why'd you love it?' and student A says, 'Because it was awesome!' and I say, 'Why was it awesome?' and student A says, 'Because I loved it.' Student A knows how she feels, but doesn't know how to explain it: how to answer the question why? She's failing to offer critical analysis. Conversely, another student might say, 'I hated it.' (Why?) 'Because it sucked.' (Why?) 'Because I hated it.' They know how they feel, but they can't turn their reaction into analysis. Critical thinking is the key to turning your opinions into smart, scholarly analysis!"

ii. **The 5-year-old:** Have you ever been around a 5-year-old who asks a lot of questions? Every answer earns another question.

b. Go over the Pre-Writing slides: read the example about Creed or Disney movies. Explain the process that they're about to go through in detail.

SLIDES 14–15

6 **Writing Activity:** students should log onto yawp.school and open their documents. Make sure that students are on the **Pre-Write** module before they begin pre-writing.

SLIDES 16–18

a. Ask students if they have any questions before they begin their own pre-write on the prompt.

b. Tell students to begin pre-writing and to follow the instructions that the Tutor gives them. For best results, remind them of the following:

SLIDE 19

i. Don't worry about grammar, syntax, or organization

ii. Don't edit as you go: just get it all out!

iii. Pre-writing is like a purging of sorts: it's about getting your opinions, reactions, and ideas onto the page. Anything goes!

iv. Ask and answer questions!

v. The more you write at this stage, the better.

c. As students pre-write, work the room. After several minutes, ask individual students if you can quickly read their work. If there are students who aren't writing, check in with them. Give positive and constructive feedback.

SLIDE 20

d. After students have pre-written for 5 minutes or so, ask them to read over what they've written and ask the Tutor for feedback. "It's always a good idea to read over what you just wrote. Sometimes when we pre-write, we're just going for it: we're in a flow state and might not even be fully aware of what we're saying. When you read over what you wrote, some of it may be messy and not useful at all, but there will be other moments that might stand out as interesting, good, complex, or worthy of more discussion."

e. The Tutor will help students identify their **“diamonds in the rough”**: specific subtopics that are coming up in their pre-write. The Tutor will instruct them to choose a “diamond” and pre-write on that. Give them time to continue pre-writing. As they continue this process, their ideas will become more specific and interesting. Eventually, they will find their specific focus for their essays. At this point, the Tutor will conclude the pre-writing process with them.

SLIDE 21

7. **Closing Slides: What have we learned today?** Direct students’ attention to the slide and ask individual students to read each point.

SLIDES 22–23

Adapted from Brian Connell’s lesson plan for the YAWP! Writing Program, with slide numbers for the new deck.